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Trails and Greenways plan becomes a reality

May 14, 2011

By MARK J. MILLER - Staff writer (mmiller@heraldstaronline.com), The Herald-Star

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STEUBENVILLE - The fruit of two years labor by the Jefferson County Trails and Greenways committee was celebrated with the unveiling of the committee's grand vision of a trails and greenways system throughout Jefferson County and beyond.

The ambitious plan, unveiled Friday at Jim Woods Park, was created after years of research and work by Jefferson County political, business and educational advocates. The plan was presented to the public through a glossy, color foldout with local photos of Jefferson County, information about the committee and a map outlining possible areas of the county that are ripe for development as trails or greenways, according to Sue Hershey, president of the Jefferson County Chamber of Commerce.

"We are unveiling the executive summary," said Hershey, adding the plan was the result of research into communities interested in becoming part of a countywide trail system. "We met with people through public meetings throughout the county."

Hershey said those areas included Wayne Elementary School in Bloomingdale, Eastern Gateway Community College, the Adena Community Center, the Toronto Municipal Building and Buckeye Local High School in Rayland.

The planned areas of potential development are stretched throughout the county, and could be linked to trails in neighboring counties and states, said Hershey. She added there will be formation of local task forces in each potential area. Those task forces would be responsible for finding funding and labor for trail development, Hershey said.

"Now that we've completed this plan those (task forces) will be able to apply for grants for funding of trails and greenways," Hershey said, adding members of the task force would be able to use resources available through the greenways committee. "These would be multi-use trails, and it took us two years to get to this point. It also will be used to (link the county trails) with those of 18 other counties in three states who would like to (link) up with Jefferson County."

Irene Moore, district administrator for the Jefferson County Water and Soil Conservation District, said the plan would be used as a catalyst to motivate area communities to begin planning on their legs of a trail system.

"What we looked at most were areas that already had trails that people use to walk," said Moore, adding the committee looked for connections between communities that took an interest in the plan. "It's not just a health benefit to have trails - it's also for business, economic development, tourism and education. Once we saw there was a definite interest (in local trails) we developed a steering committee."

Moore also said with the Jefferson County Trails and Greenways plan there is now a central vision for a trail system.

"It's now up to the communities to pull together and use the plan," she said.



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For a copy of the plan, call the Jefferson County Chamber at (740) 282-6226.

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